

One face of **Marmolada**, the **highest peak** in the Dolomites, is a near-vertical cliff **2,000 ft (600 m) high**

▽ **BOLD CLIFFS**
The topography of the Dolomites features massive rock walls, towers, and jagged pinnacles.



The Dolomites

A dramatic range in northeastern Italy, with 18 peaks rising above 10,000 ft (3,000 m)

A subrange of the Alps, the Dolomites consist of multiple layers of sedimentary rock, thousands of feet thick, that originally formed as coral reefs in shallow seas hundreds of millions of years ago. Later, these rock layers were lifted up as a result of tectonic plate movements, then eroded by glaciers to form the dramatic landscape seen today. The mountains are renowned for the fossils of coral reef animals they contain.

Pale mountains
The Dolomites are named after an 18th-century French mineralogist, Deodat de Dolomie, who was the first to describe the rock—dolomite—from which they are largely made. Dolomite is similar to limestone and typically white, cream, or light gray. Because of this, the Dolomites are also known as the Pale Mountains. Their highest peak is Marmolada at 10,968 ft (3,343 m). The spectacular scenery draws numerous climbers, skiers, paragliders, and hikers.

▷ **BUILDING BLOCK OF THE DOLOMITES**

Dolomite is the name given to a mineral, as well as to a rock. In this specimen, cream-colored dolomite crystals are seen mixed with crystals of quartz (pink) and a third, darker mineral.

dolomite crystals



ROCK LAYERS OF THE DOLOMITES

